



FROM HOURS TO SECONDS

Bringing Trustworthy AI to Marin County
Two AI pilots and a governance strategy

Joseph Bidias · Software Engineering Fellow

County of Marin · Information Services & Technology · Coding it Forward 2026



WHERE I WORKED THIS SUMMER

MARIN COUNTY

A local government serving the residents of Marin County, California. County employees deliver essential services across departments:

- Health & Human Services
- Public Works
- Sheriff's Office
- Finance & Administration
- And many more

MY ROLE

Joseph Bidias

Software Engineering Fellow, Coding it Forward.

Msc Quant Engineer from WorldQuant University.

Placed with the County's Information Services & Technology (IST) department.

My mission: help county staff use AI to serve residents faster, and safely.



THE PROBLEM

Two everyday problems in county work

WHAT I FOUND

~1 hr

Hours lost to manual work

Staff read long ballot measures and resolutions line by line to find a few financial and compliance facts. It is slow, repetitive, and easy to get wrong.

280 vs 150

More AI users than we planned for

About 280 employees are using AI tools we budgeted for 150. Use grew faster than the guidance for using it safely.

WHAT I BUILT: TWO PILOTS

Both run inside the county's existing Microsoft 365. No new purchase, and no data leaves county control.

Legal Document Analyzer

PILOT

Reads ballot measures, resolutions, and board minutes, then pulls out the key facts: fiscal years, dollar amounts, tax caps, exemptions, and approval rules. It returns a clean report and shows the source text for every field.

For finance & legal staff

HR Assistant

PILOT

Answers employee questions about benefits, leave, payroll, and training using only the county's official HR pages. It cites its source, and for anything involving private records it sends the employee to HR.

For all county employees

HOW I BUILT IT: THE TOOLS

All inside Microsoft 365. These are tools the county already owned, so nothing new had to be bought.

SP SharePoint

Where documents come in and reports go out. The county's secure file home.

PA Power Automate

The conductor. It watches a folder and runs the steps automatically.

CS Copilot Studio

The AI that reads a document or answers a question, using official county content.

ET Excel & Teams

Where results land: a clean spreadsheet, or an answer right inside Teams.

ID Entra ID + Purview

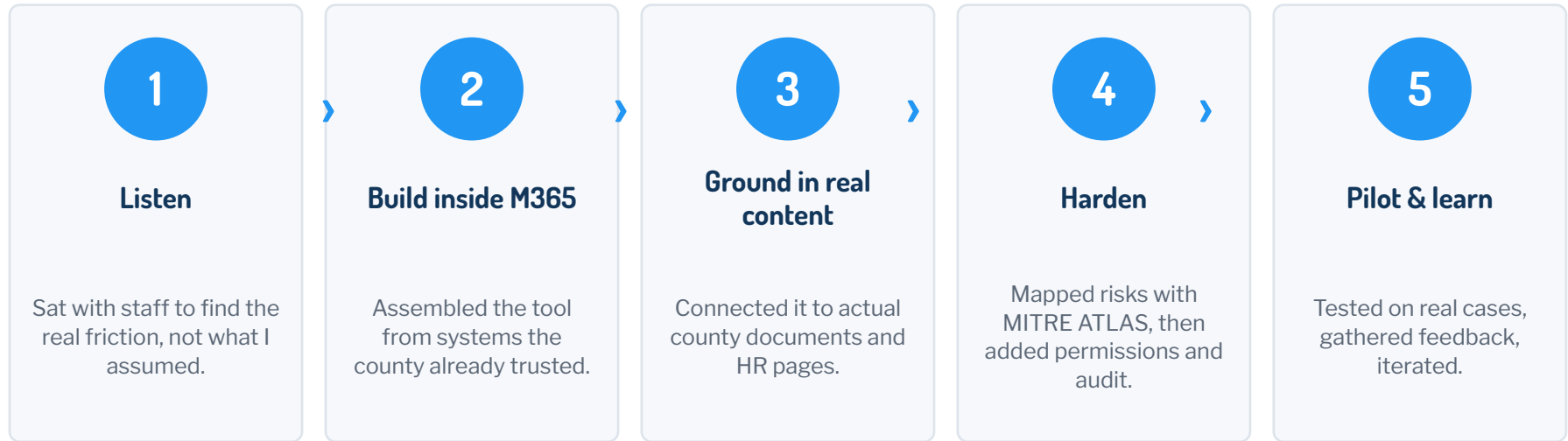
The guardrails: permissions and an audit trail on every interaction.

AT MITRE ATLAS

The AI security checklist I used to find and close risks in each tool.

HOW I BUILT IT: THE PROCESS

The same five steps for both pilots: build small, use real content, add safeguards, then test.



The order matters. Safeguards came before testing, so trust was built in from the start.

~~1 hour~~ → 60 sec

That is the time to read a ballot measure and pull out 15 key financial and compliance facts, each with a citation to the exact source sentence. The same task took a person close to an hour.

PILOT 1: SEEING IT WORK

A real example: Measure B, the Marin County Free Library parcel tax

FULL TEXT OF MEASURE B RESOLUTION NO. 2022-66

RESOLUTION OF THE MARIN COUNTY BOARD OF SUPERVISORS LIBRARY CALLING FOR AN ELECTION TO IMPOSE A SPECIAL TAX UPON PARCELS LOCATED WITHIN THE COUNTY OF MARIN FOR THE PURPOSE OF PROVIDING ESSENTIAL FUNDING TO PROTECT AND MAINTAIN LIBRARY SERVICES.

WHEREAS, the Board of Supervisors determines that it is the best interest of property owners within the Marin County Free Library District to place a levy on parcels served by the Marin County Free Library to provide critical funding for library services and facilities for the residents of the District and to fund said services through imposition of a special tax; and

WHEREAS, pursuant to California Education Code Section 19172, California Government Code Section 29100 et seq. and 50073 et seq., Revenue and Taxation Code Section 2151, et seq., and in compliance with California Constitution Article XIIIIC, the Board of Supervisors is hereby authorized to adopt this resolution to establish and impose (subject to voter approval) a special tax upon all taxable real property located within the Marin County Free Library; and

WHEREAS, Marin County voters previously adopted a special tax for library services for the Marin County Free Library, beginning in the fiscal year 2015-2016, which is set to expire on June 30, 2024; and

WHEREAS, the Board of Supervisors proposes to renew the special tax in the amounts specified below beginning fiscal year 2024-2025 and continuing through June 30, 2032; and

WHEREAS, the special tax continuing for a period of nine (9) years, if approved by the electorate, will not exceed the spending limit pursuant to California Constitution Article XIIIIC; and

WHEREAS, the Board of Supervisors conducted public hearings on July 12, 2022 and July 19, 2022.

NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the special tax of \$98 dollars per parcel annually beginning fiscal year 2024-2025 and continuing through June 30, 2032 established by this Resolution shall be submitted to the registered voters within the Marin County Free Library District in the General Election on November 5, 2022. Pursuant to Election Code section 10400 et seq., the election for this special tax shall be coordinated with the General Election on that date. The Marin County Registrar of Voters will be reimbursed for the incremental costs of said election if the measure is approved by the voters. The Registrar of Voters is hereby requested to publish the full text of this Resolution in the Marin County Free Library District.

paragraph. The question submitted to the voters shall read substantially as follows:

"To provide critical funding, that can't be taken by the State, to:

- maintain library hours and 24/7 online library access;
- enhance programs for children, teens, adults, seniors;
- increase book/digital collections;
- provide free internet access and computers;
- upgrade library facilities.

shall the Marin County Free Library measure be adopted increasing the currently approved library parcel tax to \$98 a year, providing \$4.7 million dollars annually, for 9 years, with annual adjustments, independent citizen oversight and senior citizen exemptions?"

YES	
NO	

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the special tax is for the specific purpose of preserving library closures; maintaining library hours and 24/7 online library access; enhancing programs for children, teens, adults, and seniors; preventing staff buy-outs; increasing collections of books and digital materials; providing free internet access and computers; upgrading library facilities and ensuring local funding that can't be taken by the State.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the proceeds for the special tax to be applied only to the specific purposes stated above.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that should the electorate approve the special tax, a special account will be created into which the special tax proceeds will be deposited.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the chief fiscal officer is hereby directed to prepare an annual report pursuant to Government Code Section 50073.5.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Marin County Board of Supervisors will appoint the Library Commission as an independent citizen oversight committee to ensure that the funds are spent as described above.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that a "parcel" shall be defined as any parcel of land, developed or undeveloped, wholly or partially located within the District, for which the County Assessor of Marin County has assigned an assessor's identification number, provided, however, that any such parcels which are contiguous, held under identical ownership, map, upon approval of an application of the assessor for the Parcel of Parcel Taxation.

TAX RATE

\$98 / parcel / yr

ANNUAL REVENUE

\$4.7 million

SENIOR EXEMPTION

Age 65 and over

DURATION

9 years (to 2033)

MAX INCREASE

3% per year (CPI)

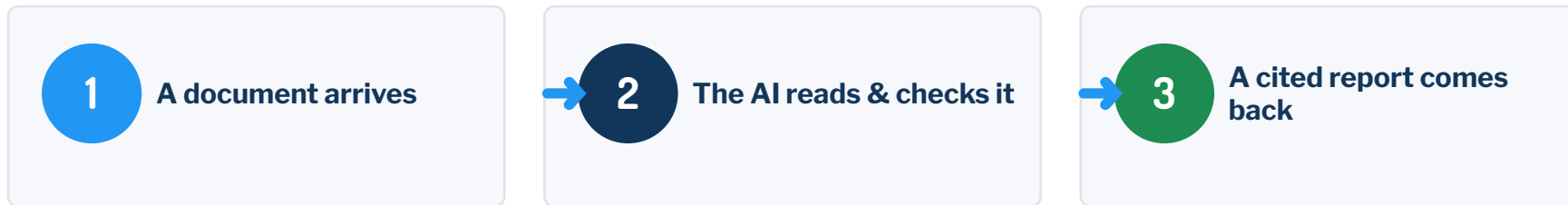
APPROVAL NEEDED

2/3 voter majority

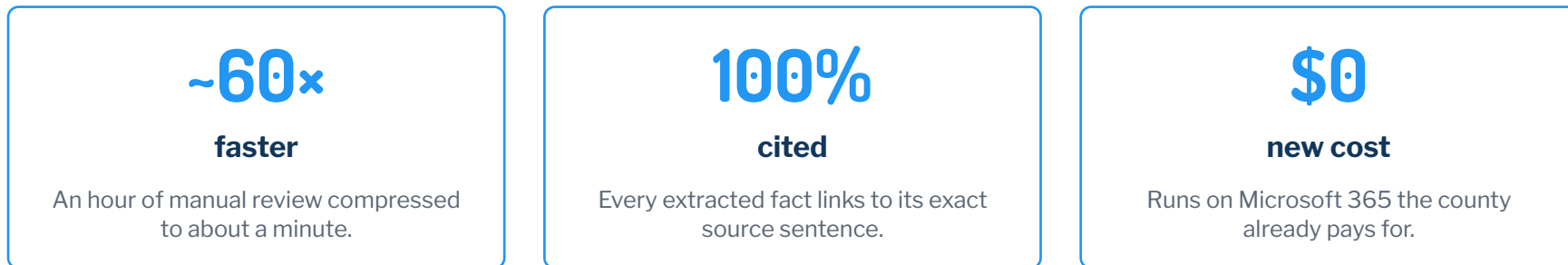
Source: Resolution No. 2022-66

Every fact links back to the exact sentence in the source document, so a reviewer can check it in seconds.

PILOT 1: HOW IT WORKS & THE IMPACT



THE IMPACT



PILOT 2: THE HR ASSISTANT

For every county employee. It answers from official HR content, cites its source, and knows when to say no.

IT ANSWERS: GROUNDED & CITED

“How do I enroll in County benefits?”

“What leave types am I eligible for?”

“Who do I contact about a payroll issue?”

“What training academies are available?”

IT REFUSES: BY DESIGN

“What is my coworker's salary?”

For private records such as salary, performance, medical, or leave balances, it declines and points the employee to HR.

Knowing when to say no is part of the design.

PILOT 2: THE IMPACT

Every

employee

Reaches all county staff, not just one team. This is the widest-reach pilot.

24/7

instant answers

HR questions answered any time, without waiting on a ticket.

Cited

& in-scope

Grounded in official HR pages; refuses private-record questions by design.

Pilot outcome: it answers routine HR questions quickly while keeping private data out of reach.

THE BIGGER PICTURE

Beyond the pilots, I wrote a countywide strategy for using AI wisely

● Right tool for the work

Match each employee to the AI tool their job needs, so the county stops paying for tools people do not use.

● Data stays governed

Clear rules keep resident and employee information secure, auditable, and inside county control.

● One trusted front door

A vision for one simple assistant, inspired by California's Poppy platform, that guides staff to the right help.

● A timely opportunity

California's new Anthropic partnership offers counties Claude at 50% off with free training. That is a real chance to expand access.

LESSONS LEARNED

1 The hard part wasn't the AI

The real learning came from the plumbing: workflow imports, secure pages, and permissions. The unglamorous solutions are what make a tool reliable.

2 Trust is a feature, not an add-on

In government, an answer is not useful unless people can verify it. Citations and human review were not extras. They were the center of the design.

3 Adoption beats capability

The best tool is worthless if no one trusts or uses it. Matching tools to real work matters more than raw model power.



CALL TO ACTION

The next step is a supervised, opt-in rollout that proves trust at small scale before going countywide.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

With thanks to the Marin County IST team, my supervisor and colleagues, and Coding it Forward, for the trust, guidance, and the chance to serve.

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2026



THANK YOU !

Q/A